

‘DEV BHOOMI’ TRANSFORMING INTO ‘YOG BHOOMI’

The cultural significance of yoga in Uttarakhand is unparalleled. Nestled amidst the breathtaking landscapes of the Himalayas, this region is a haven for those seeking both physical well-being and spiritual enlightenment. Throughout history, Uttarakhand has remained a cherished destination for spiritual seekers, drawing visionaries and leaders from diverse backgrounds. Eminent figures such as Swami Vivekananda sought solace amidst the tranquil vistas of Kausani, while the revered Maharishi Mahesh Yogi received the profound teachings of transcendental meditation in Rishikesh. The iconic Chaurasi Kutiya witnessed The Beatles' transformative journey, while the ethereal serenity of Kainchi Dham left an indelible impression on modern-day pioneers like Steve Jobs and Mark Zuckerberg. Even Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been inspired by the spiritual aura of Kedarnath.

Fuelled by the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Dhami is spearheading a plan to elevate the state as a global hub of yoga. A draft of the state's first yoga policy has been meticulously crafted. This policy endeavors to promote holistic well-being through education, collaboration, and the establishment of world-class centers dedicated to the practice and teachings of yoga.

The proposed Yoga policy outlines ambitious targets for the state. Within three years, yoga and meditation will be integrated as structured extra-curricular activities in every school across Uttarakhand. Additionally, within one year, 100% of AYUSH health and wellness centers will offer yoga and meditation services. The policy also aims to register at least 50 Yoga Centres/Training Institutes under the Wellness Registration Online Portal within one year, with a target of 100% registration within three years. An annual global yoga event will be hosted in Uttarakhand, inviting practitioners and experts from around the world to participate actively. Moreover, the proposed policy envisions the establishment of Yoga infrastructure, including meditation caves, Vipassana centers, and Yoga Retreats in major tourist destinations within the next five years. An International Yoga Research Institute is slated for establishment within three years.

To promote Uttarakhand as a holistic wellness center, a long-term brand development action plan will be implemented, focusing on Ayurveda, Yoga, and Meditation. Short-term initiatives include launching community-based mindfulness programs and adopting a standardized yoga teacher certification system. The state plans to introduce its exclusive online yoga and meditation platform, aiming to connect over 1 lakh users within five years. Furthermore, research grants will be provided to support five yoga and meditation projects, fostering innovation and development in this domain.

Proposed Yoga Policy is accompanied by a comprehensive action plan aimed at achieving its outlined goals. Firstly, yoga will be introduced as a compulsory extra-curricular activity in schools and colleges, beginning with daily holistic yoga sessions. Uttarakhand Ayurved University will spearhead the development and integration of a clinically oriented yoga education curriculum for colleges, including the introduction of BNYS (Bachelor of Naturopathy and Yogic Sciences) programs. Additionally, the Medical Council of India will launch a practical-focused, two-year diploma course in yoga, equipping students not only with practical knowledge but also with hospitality skills to foster entrepreneurship in the field. To ensure uniformity and quality in yoga education, the Government of Uttarakhand will implement a standardized yoga instructor certification system and examination for trainers, instructors, and teachers. This initiative aims to establish consistent quality standards across the state. Furthermore, dedicated yoga and meditation rooms will be established for

